



8-3-2021 MCS Executive Board Meeting

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xk-nHd5mCLM
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1. Pre-Meeting Hearings & Committee Work Sessions

(Omitted: No statutory public hearing or separate committee session was held prior to calling the regular meeting to order.)

2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** Opening statements and meeting proceedings were led by the presiding officer for Muncie Community Schools (MCS). The meeting was conducted as a special session to address reopening plans and student masking guidelines ahead of the school year.
- **Attendance:**
 - **Members Present:** Dr. O'Neal, Mr. Heater, Mrs. Bales, Mrs. Barnes Griffin, Mr. Irvin, Mr. Lowe.
 - **Members Absent:** None explicitly noted.
 - **Presiding Officer:** Identified as the board president/chair.

3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** The meeting opened with the Pledge of Allegiance led by Megan [00:01:28](#).
- **Approval of Minutes:** Not addressed in the transcript.

4. Substantive Business & Board Action

00:12:02 Consideration of the MCS Reopening Plan & Mask Mandate

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Dr. Kwakowski (Superintendent) and the Board President.
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - The board reviewed the updated back-to-school reopening plan in light of rising COVID-19 cases (noting 24 cases in Delaware County the previous day) and updated guidance from the CDC and the Indiana State Department of Health recommending universal masking for K-12 schools.
 - Officials noted that local healthcare partners at IU Ball Memorial Health strongly urged a mandatory mask policy due to low county vaccination rates (around 40%) and risks posed by the Delta variant, particularly to children under 12 who were ineligible for vaccination.
 - Board members discussed the balance between the social/emotional impacts of masking on students and the long-term health risks and potential for school closures. Members emphasized that the policy would be evaluated on an ongoing basis rather than locked in for the entire semester or year, with administrative flexibility to adapt to changing data.
- **Item-Specific Public Input:**
 - **00:03:32 Mr. Klotz** (Parent/Grandparent and taxpayer): Spoke against a mask mandate, arguing that masks should be optional, citing concerns over the psychological and physical toll on children, carbon dioxide intake, and noting that surrounding districts had adopted mask-optional policies.
 - **00:08:54 Tiffany** (Parent): Spoke against a mask mandate, sharing personal observations of her middle school son's social withdrawal under previous masking and asking when mandates would end if tied to mutated viruses like the flu.
 - **00:11:08 Margie Harvey** (Resident): Expressed concern regarding quarantine rules for working single parents if positive cases occurred in schools operating under mask-optional policies.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote (Mandatory masking for all students, staff, and visitors, with regular administrative review).

5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

(Note: General public comments regarding the reopening plan occurred earlier in the meeting prior to board deliberation, documented under Section 4 above.)

6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:** Board members noted that reopening protocols, seating configurations (removing the requirement for all desks to face the same direction, based on updated health department guidance), and quarantine guidelines for vaccinated vs. unvaccinated individuals would be distributed by administration.
- **Adjournment:** The meeting was officially adjourned by voice vote following a motion and second 00:34:47.

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